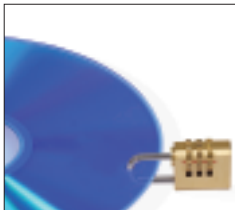




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Digital Passion

Fuelling The Pursuit Of Technology Knowledge

Cover Story

How Secure are you?

Enticing email subjects and images could lead your system and security to peril...

Edward Henning

There is no such thing as a completely secure computer, or IT network. The number of threats we face from pranksters, all the way to organised crime is growing all the time. In fact, the threats themselves are increasing in both seriousness and sophistication.

It's not just a matter of viruses, trojans or worms that might come attached to an email and then infect your machine. If you are on the internet, then you are open to attacks of many different kinds, from hackers trying to gain direct access to your computer, malicious web sites tricking you into parting with money, tricks to get personal details such as credit card information or passwords, software slipped onto your PC that will do any number of things without detection — the list is always growing. As computers, software and the internet become more feature-rich and complex, the number of ways in which attacks can occur also inevitably increases. Everybody needs to be vigilant, particularly where online transactions involving banking or online shopping are concerned.

The original web pages that people surfed early in the 90s consisted only of text formatted with HTML together with images, tables and the like. Not much risk was involved. But things are now much more complex. You have embedded videos, JavaScript menus, PHP code and many more rich and interactive features. With this level of complexity also come programming errors and loopholes. At the best, these problems cause difficulties with the straightforward operation of a site. At the worst, they enable an attacker to take over a site, grab personal information or infiltrate hidden software onto your PC.

The language used in security circles

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